

Rainforests and Woods



THE LUSH TROPICAL RAINFORESTS of northeastern Australia are very different from the dry interior of the continent. Hot and damp, they provide a home for an unusual variety of animals, from tree kangaroos to spectacular birds of paradise. Similar wildlife is found in the misty mountain forests of New Guinea, an island about 1,400 miles (2,200 km) long, which lies off northern Australia. In the southwest and southeast of Australia there are cooler, drier eucalyptus woods, where rain falls mainly during the winter months. Many birds nest there in the winter and early spring. The trees and shrubs are a rich source of nectar and pollen for animals such as parrots and bats.



Sydney funnel-web spider
(*Atrax robustus*)
Length: up to 1.3 in (3.5 cm)

Silky killer

The funnel-web spider lives in a burrow with an entrance shaped like a funnel. It lines the burrow with a silky web, which is extremely sticky. At night, the spider emerges to seize small animals, insects, and other prey. It injects venom into its victims and is one of the few spiders that can kill people.



Rainbow lorikeet
(*Trichoglossus moluccanus*)
Length: up to 12 in (30 cm)

Furry parachute

The sugar glider has webs of skin between its front and back legs, which it stretches out like a parachute to slow down as it glides between trees. It can cover distances of more than 164 ft (50 m) in one glide. The sugar glider feeds on insects, nectar, fruit, and the sweet, sugary sap of the eucalyptus tree.

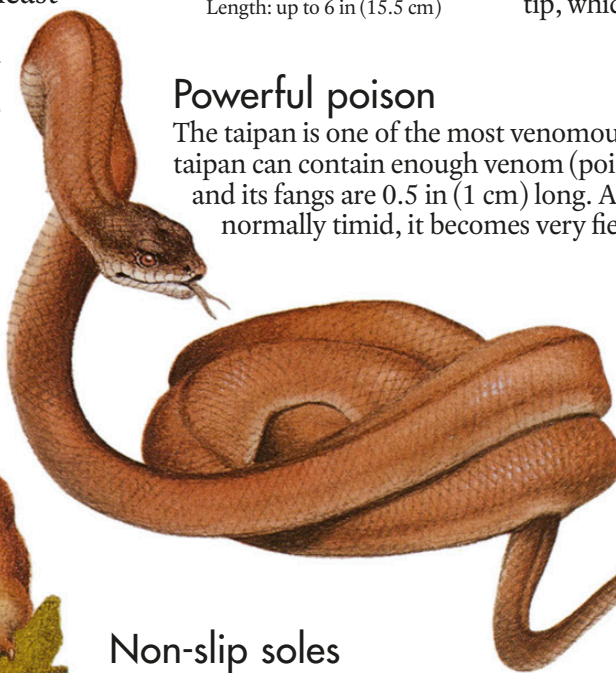


Taipan
(*Oxyuranus scutellatus*)
Length: up to 10 ft 10 in (3.3 m)



Powerful poison

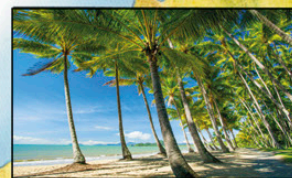
The taipan is one of the most venomous snakes in the world. One taipan can contain enough venom (poison) to kill 125,000 mice, and its fangs are 0.5 in (1 cm) long. Although the taipan is normally timid, it becomes very fierce when threatened.



Non-slip soles

The tree kangaroo has strong, wide paws with rough pads and sharp claws to help it climb in the trees. Its long tail helps the kangaroo balance on branches.

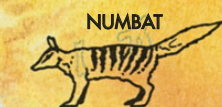
Goodfellow's tree kangaroo
(*Dendrolagus goodfellowi*)
Body length: up to 2 ft 9 in (84.5 cm)
Tail: up to 2 ft 9 in (85.5 cm)



Many palm trees grow on Australia's coastal plain.

Dancing display

The rainbow lorikeet hops and preens to warn other lorikeets to keep out of its territory. The male uses similar moves to win a female during courtship.



NUMBAT



HONEY POSSUM



WESTERN SPINEBILL

Sugar glider
(*Petaurus breviceps*)
Body length: up to 8 in (21 cm)
Tail: up to 8 in (21 cm)



Western spinebill
(*Acanthorhynchus superciliosus*)
Length: up to 6 in (15.5 cm)



Nectar eater

The western spinebill uses its long, curved bill to probe for nectar in flowers. Its tongue has a brush at the tip, which the bird uses to lap up nectar.



QUEEN ALEXANDRA'S BIRDWING BUTTERFLY



Dense rainforest vegetation in eastern New Guinea.

